



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

MGN 715 (M+F) Recommended Best Practice for Respectful and Safe Operation in Shared Spaces

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Summary

This Marine Guidance Notice (MGN) sets out recommended best practice to encourage respectful operation between different water users. The range of water user types sharing the maritime space has diversified in recent years (e.g. such as the increased use of personal watercraft and autonomous or automated vessels).

This MGN has been produced to:

- Inform water users with less experience of the maritime environment of their responsibilities; and
- Provide a reminder to experienced water users of their responsibilities; particularly in terms of risks due to diverse water users sharing busy areas.

1. Navigation and Watchkeeping

1.1. A good lookout shall be kept at all times using all available visual and auditory resources, and any other equipment.

1.2. All factors, including but not limited to, the sea-state, weather, and state of visibility likely to be encountered during the voyage, and whether the surrounding waters are congested should be considered before going to sea.

1.3. A vessel should proceed at a safe speed which would enable a vessel to take appropriate actions to avoid collisions, close quarter situations, or to stop. The safe speed should be appropriate to the prevailing circumstances and operational conditions (for example: visibility, traffic density or proximity to navigational hazards).

1.4. Vessel operators are required to be familiar with their responsibilities under COLREGs.^[footnote 1]

1.5. Requirements for lights and shapes should be complied with in all weathers. Requirements for lights should be complied with from sunset to sunrise.^[footnote 2]

1.6. A vessel using a Traffic Separation Scheme (TSS) shall proceed in the appropriate lane in the general direction of traffic flow.

1.7. All operators should have a good level of familiarity with COLREGs and, where appropriate, local navigation rules.

1.8. All water users should demonstrate patience and consideration of others when operating in congested waters.

2. Effective Communication

2.1. All water users should respond in a prompt and polite manner to signals or radiocommunications received from other water users and the Coastguard.

2.2. Automatic Identification System (AIS) transponders, where installed, should be kept switched on and transmitting for the entirety of the vessel's voyage.

2.3. VHF radio Channel 16 should be monitored at all times and only used for distress, urgency or safety calls, or to establish initial contact with a vessel.

2.4. Manoeuvres should always be signalled early and in good time.

3. Shared Maritime Spaces

3.1. Local navigation rules should be followed, and steps should be taken to ensure awareness of any restrictions (e.g. Notice to Mariners, nautical charts or isolated danger marks).

3.2. All water users shall take care to ensure that the operation of their vessel does not result in damage or dislodging of equipment or

infrastructure, including commonly found items in a marine environment such as:

- fishing nets;
- fishing lines;
- lobster pots;
- marker buoys.

3.3. A safe distance shall be kept from divers and vessels engaged in diving activities.

3.4. Steps should be taken to minimise the impact of your vessel's wake on other water users, such as by reducing speed or giving ample space, particularly when operating in crowded areas. It is important to have a good understanding and appreciation of how your vessel's wake affect other water users (e.g. anchored vessels, fishing vessels with gear deployed or personal watercraft).

3.5 When overtaking other vessels plenty of space should be given. Extra space should be given to fishing vessels with their gear deployed, vessels which are undertaking, towing or are being towed, anchored vessels, and vessels NUC or RAM.

More Information

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Please note that all addresses and telephone numbers are correct at time of publishing.

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1. Convention of the International Regulations for Preventing Collisions at Sea, 1972.

The Merchant Shipping (Distress Signals and Prevention of Collisions) Regulations 1996 (SI 1996/075)

2. Convention of the International Regulations for Preventing Collisions at Sea, 1972; Part C



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